those who are 18 years of age or above. India is producing enough COVID-19 vaccines now to get this done. Walk-in centres should be open for all. Our country is now doing good in terms of the production of vaccines. Rather than creating criteria on the eligibility, age groups with comorbidities, etc., we should create a category of ineligible people.'[41] This marked the beginning of vaccine politicization. His comments on the vaccine roll-out too came just a day after a video conference with the prime minister in which three other opposition parties' chief ministers had also requested for the expansion of the vaccine drive. Oddly, these states demanding for the opening up of the vaccination drive hadn't even completed vaccinating frontline workers and priority groups. The chief ministers were being informed in detail of the vaccine pipeline, how much stock they had and how much the Centre was expecting, on a regular basis by the health secretary and Dr V.K. Paul. Despite the knowledge, politicizing the vaccine roll-out took centre stage. In some states, shortages were deliberately made to appear so that this vaccine shortage narrative could be pushed forward. For instance, in Maharashtra, when a vaccine shortage situation was being politically created, the health minister Rajesh Tope was redirecting thousands of doses to his constituency Jalna, from the doses which were meant for high caseload areas, thus creating scarcity in other areas of the state.[42] Continued mud-slinging on the issue of vaccine shortage, pricing and the roll-out plan saw the Centre on the back foot with changing demands on-the-go from the Opposition-ruled states and parties.

By 1 May, the next phase of the vaccination drive which would include people over the age of 18 had opened up. The enthusiasm in the youth to get vaccinated was palpable, with over 1.2 crore individuals registering on CoWIN even before the slots to book vaccine appointments became available. Due to the limited amount of vaccines, not everyone who tried was able to make a booking. The situation remained like this for several weeks, until the time more vaccines became available, prompting the opposition parties to once again attack the government on vaccine shortages. Posters were put by various opposition parties in several cities calling out the Vaccine Maitri initiative, asking, 'Modiji, why did you send our kids' vaccines abroad?' The absurdity of the poster was that India hadn't approved any vaccines for children then, let alone fall short of them! The media was relentless in blaming the government about why enough pre-orders weren't placed with vaccine manufacturers and why certain foreign